

00731

ENGLISH

(Paper—I)

Full Marks : 100

Time : 3 hours

*The figures in the margin indicate full marks
for the questions*

1. Write an essay on any one of the following topics : 30

- (a) The role of Skill India Mission in bridging the education and employability gap
- (b) Mental health in India : A neglected public health priority
- (c) Assam's economic growth : Tourism as the game changer
- (d) Risk of cyber bullying in social media

2. Read the passage given below and answer the questions that follow :

Literary awards like the Nobel Prize in Literature and the Booker Prize recognize the power of storytelling across cultures, languages and Continents. These prestigious awards not only celebrate outstanding literary achievements but also bring global attention to pressing social issues explored through literature.

In 2024, the Nobel Prize in Literature was awarded to Han Kang, the South Korean author of acclaimed works such as *The Vegetarian* and *Human Acts*. The Swedish Academy praised her "intense poetic prose" and her courage in confronting historical trauma and silence, especially those surrounding the Gwangju Uprising in Korea. Her stories reflect the inner conflict of characters who navigate between personal pain, the weight of memory and collective grief.

The 2024 Booker Prize was awarded to Samantha Harvey, a British author, for her novel, *Orbital*. The book, set on the International Space Station, unfolds over a single day and reveals the interior thoughts and emotional struggles of six astronauts orbiting Earth. The judging panel described *Orbital* as "a haunting meditation on Earth, solitude and connection", emphasizing its lyrical beauty and universal resonance in a time of global environmental uncertainty. In a proud moment for Indian literature, Banu Mushtaq, a writer from Karnataka, won the 2025 International Booker Prize for her Kannada short story collection *Heart Lamp*. Translated into English by Deepa Bhashti, the book gives voice to the untold stories of rural Indian women, who live on the social margins. Mushtaq says, "I write because their pain won't let me sleep". Her win is a milestone for regional Indian literature on the international stage.

These awards show that literature is a powerful tool for exploring human emotions, questioning injustice, and bridging cultures. Whether from the heart of Seoul, a space station, or rural India, these voices remind us of the universal desire for dignity, justice and meaning.

Questions :

- (a) According to the passage, how do literary awards like the Nobel Prize and Booker Prize contribute to Global Literature? 5
 - (b) What are the themes explored in Han Kang's work, according to the passage? 5
 - (c) Describe the unique setting of Samantha Harvey's *Orbital* and the main idea it explores. 5
 - (d) What makes Banu Mushtaq's win significant for Indian literature? Give your opinion. 5
 - (e) Identify a common message that connects the works of all three authors mentioned in the passage. 5
3. Write a précis of the following passage within one-third of its length and provide an appropriate title : 20

One of the outstanding features of the century has been the improvement in living conditions of the working man, greater political power, more wealth and leisure, and better facilities for health, security and education.

In early civilizations, most communities were sharply divided into two classes those who laboured and those who did not. The small number of rulers—kings, priests, military leaders—lived in great comfort, and did very little work. The vast majority of the population enjoyed very few comforts, did lot of work, and had scarcely any political power. In some societies, there was an even more wretched class, the slaves, who had no rights at all.

The Industrial Revolution of Europe led to the production of vast quantities of goods, and workers began to be dissatisfied with their poverty. The factory owners needed skilled workers, and gradually they realized that they must show goodwill to their workforce, in order to stay in business. As in many other reforms, some enlightened slowly spread that workers were entitled to some consideration. Since men were free to work for any master they chose, good master soon had the pick of the workers and old fashioned employers found themselves with a factory full of lower-grade workforce. Such a situation soon led to an all-round improvement in standards, and good employers tried to raise working conditions still higher. These improvements were speeded up by the increased organization of workers in Trade Union movements, particularly in low-standard factories, where the owner often had to deal with strike action by dissatisfied workers.

Now that the working classes are getting better and better working conditions, the need to strike has lessened considerably; and employers and workers alike have come to realize that they depend on each other for their livelihood.

4. As a Block Education Officer, submit a comprehensive report to the Inspector of Schools of your district detailing the infrastructural damage a recent storm has caused to a primary school within your block. Draft the report which should include specific details of the damages. Also make sure to conclude the report with a recommendation for prompt repair and restoration measures. 25

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